moment: both of us realising that he had crossed the divide for nothing, wrecked our friendship and compromised our dignity without benefit. Court seems long, but it is never as long as memory: I have never spoken to him again. In some ways, my ethics must be simple-minded, but I am not a politician: I couldn't abuse a private or a working friendship for a public gain. I just couldn't. And for someone who was part of a group called the Subversives to ally himself with the pieties of the law in times of strife, well, I felt very sorry. Trax did similarly well and would have done so without coughing up: the judge in his case ordered that no conviction be recorded against him.

My case presented itself first to the Supreme Court – almost as a point of order, or as a case study, to help define the terms of the trial – and this allowed us to seek an understanding of what the charges meant. What exactly did it mean to accuse someone of gaining access to a computer? If there was commercial data on the system that was not read by the intruder, does he still stand accused of theft? If a crook breaks into a house and steals that day's newspaper, is he then liable to stand trial for the theft of the Matisse that was hanging over the sitting-room fireplace? The Supreme Court, however, wanted to make a point to the County Courts that they should not send matters to them except in extreme circumstances. This was a shame, as it would prove a missed opportunity when it came to future computer crimes cases. The law failed its own benchmark of intellectual curiosity that day, and everybody suffered, not least Australia itself, which even today fails to spot the difference between a child molester and a person interested in using computers to secure our liberties.

In the end, I was tried before a judge who knew little of the case. He made it clear he would have preferred a custodial sentence, but, following a code of parity, he gave me a similar sentence to that enjoyed by Prime Suspect. My good behaviour bond was ten times greater and I had less time to pay the $2,100 reparation. I was tarred as a criminal, and I minded that, of course; but there was some relief that I wouldn't, this time, be going to jail. Nobody would be opening champagne, and I had a working life to rebuild, but the case taught me how vulnerable hackers would be in the future. I walked into that court already a different person from the boy who had hacked into Nortel, and my dander was up, as they say, not to follow the logic of the court, which was primitive in my view, but to follow the logic of mathematics and exploration, and go further into the realms of